

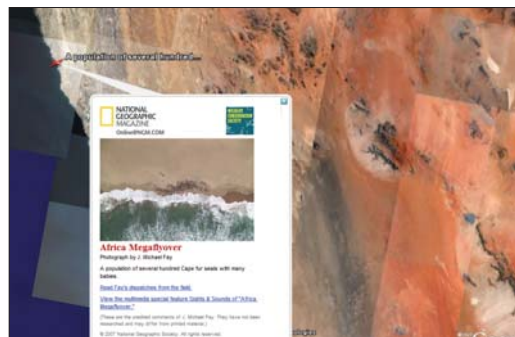
One of the features we liked was the bonus system—to ensure that your child doesn't get attached to just one program, you can assign bonus points to applications that you want your child to access on a regular basis, multiplication tables for instance. These points can then be used to access other applications like games or the browser. The message you send your child is clear—do your duties and your rights will follow.

Once the ten-use demo expires, you can purchase Magic Desktop for \$29.99 (Rs 1,350), and we highly recommend that you do.

Google Earth

<http://earth.google.com/>

Children don't like geography, mostly. Think back to times when you really couldn't care less



Don't you wish you had this when you were in school?

what the Steppes were (we used to think grasslands were really big gardens) and the world's miscellaneous geographical formations were just new words to remember.

Google Earth takes all that away and actually makes learning about the world fun—it brings the Atlas to life. We don't really need to tell you much about it—it's been talked about in these pages many times, and you've got it off our DVD often (at least, we hope you have). A lot of new overlays have been added to the new Google Earth—you can now view photos from Panoramio, a community project that matches photos to the locations they were taken at. You can take a photograph of the neighbourhood garden, for example, and mark the garden's location on Google Earth—anyone moving over that area will then be able to see your photo. The whole process of touring the earth looking at everyone's photos can be mesmerising. But we digress.

It shouldn't take much thought to assess Google Earth's educational value—schoolchildren will be able to appreciate the places they read about better when they've seen them from above, for one. Turn on the National Geographic Magazine layer in the left pane to take your child through their Africa Megaflyover—interesting sights (no sounds) from the Dark Continent. Geographical formations will also make much more sense when you get to see what they look like outside the textbook.

You could even recommend it to your child's schoolteacher, and maybe you'll have a classful of geography geeks on your hands.

Celestia

www.shatters.net/celestia/

What Google Earth is to, well, Earth, Celestia is to the universe! All right, so that's perhaps a tad

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exaggerated—though Celestia is based on actual data gathered by the Hubble space telescope, and it does let you navigate to planets and stars and view them from any angle you like.



Boldly go where no child has gone before

The universe that you view is supposedly in the state it should be at that instant—if you see the Earth at point X in Celestia, it's estimated that it's at the same point in real life. We can't really verify this, what with being unable to afford a trip to space, but we're told that the estimate is more than dependable. The interface is quite easy to use—if you're on a random star-hunt, just click on a star you like (double-click to centre that star in your view) and hit [G] to go to it. After a brief, very *Star Trek*-like trip, you're at the star you chose, with a little scientific information about the star at the upper-left corner of the screen. The best way to start with Celestia, though, is to run the demo ([D]), which takes you through the Solar System, some popular constellations, an interesting star or two, and a view of the Milky Way. It also gives you an idea of the features you have at your disposal—viewing the orbits of heavenly bodies, for instance.

For even more educational value, download the Celestia Educational Activities add-on from <http://celestiamotherlode.net/catalog/educational.php>—the tours of the universe (complete with sound) are more exhilarating than your first day at the planetarium. Each activity comes with a guide for educators—helpful if you're teaching a group of children about the universe.

Scratch

<http://scratch.mit.edu/>

You can't argue that software programming isn't a lucrative career today—and India's already booming IT industry still has a long climb ahead of it—we haven't built our answer to Microsoft yet, have we. We're not asking you to breed software engineers, but monetary promises aside, programming also teaches children to think analytically, break down problems to little bits, and generally figure out how technology works.

The researchers at MIT's Lifelong Kindergarten project have come up with the Scratch programming language, which teaches children programming through visual elements. Loops, for example, are shown as bright orange clamps that enclose code, and the code itself is a bunch of statements inside interconnecting blocks. Think of it as drawing a flowchart before actually coding, only the flowchart is the code itself. The resultant program isn't one of those boring old

